

The Hits AND MISSES

A young scion steps into his legacy and leads his party to a decisive win as an aged warhorse fades away into the sunset, his dream unfulfilled. The comrade-in-chief loses his bluster while the caste queen is dwarfed by her own shadow.

RAHUL GANDHI

A Leader Is Born

Until now he was busy discovering India. Now it seems that India has discovered Rahul Gandhi. There are three clear winners of this election—one is the young scion who shares the honours with two seasoned chief ministers, Nitish Kumar and Naveen Patnaik. From the start, with the decision that the Congress should not contest under a UPA umbrella, it is Rahul who has been dictating the party's campaign. A proud mother stepped back and let the son dictate the Congress response to the electoral challenge. Neither she, nor a less trusting Congress, was disappointed.

Now, sycophantic Congressmen want more. But Sonia Gandhi and her son are sticking to the old script that has Manmohan Singh as prime minister and sees Rahul gradually firming his hold over the party. To help him take control of his legacy are his band of young MPs (almost all have won). Season Two of Manmohan's Government will see a younger, and a much more photogenic Cabinet.

In retrospect, it is of course very easy to see a method behind Rahul's idealistic leadership. The young leader's strategy of focusing on the organisation instead of going for opportunistic alliances has paid off. He refused to let either mockery or ridicule deter him from his task. His school-boyish campaign of overnight sleepovers at Dalit households clearly struck a deeper chord than Mayawati's self-glorifying spree of installing her own statues. An amazed Congress watched in delight as the lost heartland finally turned in its favour. The Congress has more than doubled its count of nine MPs in Uttar Pradesh in 2004. Rahul has called it a vote in favour of development and against the traditional politics of caste. It is also a vote for the kind of politics that the earnest



RAHUL PROVED HIS CRITICS WRONG BY CRAFTING A SURPRISING WIN FOR THE CONGRESS

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI